4

Innovations and Ideas

AT THE TIME SORABJI ESTABLISHED the Central Bank, other banks were content to plod the beaten track of business and profits alone, and confined their activities solely to banking operations. There was no understanding of the role a bank could play in generating among the people an awareness of how a bank could cater to their financial needs. As we have already seen, the Central Bank was born in a milieu which was far from encouraging. It had to overcome the prejudice against a swadeshi bank and simultaneously cultivate the field in which it could prosper. An uninstructed public opinion could not appreciate how a swadeshi bank could further national welfare; and the savings habit taken for granted in our times had yet to become the commonplace it is now. This applied all the more to the poor for whom the bank was a mysterious institution far removed from their interests. Thus, Sorabji not only had to contend with animus from other banks and a host of detractors only too keen in seeing the demise of the Central Bank, but also had to promote the savings habit particularly among the poorer sections of the populace. As Nanporia observes, 'It was into these uninspiring circumstances that Sorabji erupted with all the élan of a far-seeing innovator, bringing about a sort of partnership between the bank and the people, both stimulating each other to a progressively higher level of mutual awareness.'[1] In twenty-five years, Sorabji had not only created a bank and established it on a sound footing, but simultaneously also created the field in which it could operate successfully.

INNOVATIONS